

Agency Manager — Admin Guide

Version 1.4.0 — for day-to-day site administrators

1. Overview

Agency Manager is a single admin product for running a talent, casting, model, or location agency website: Talent and Location profiles, public application forms with a review workflow, three Display Modes, Elementor widgets, shortcodes, and JSON import/export — all reachable from one Dashboard.

The admin menu is organized as: Dashboard, Talent, Locations, Applications, Forms, Website Display, Import/Export, and Settings.

2. Dashboard

Agency Manager -> Dashboard is the starting point for daily use.

- Stat tiles: Total Talent, Featured Talent, Active Talent, Talent Display Mode, Total Locations, Featured Locations, Active Locations, Locations Display Mode, Pending Applications, Approved Applications.
- Recent Activity: the latest Talent, Location, and Application entries, each linking straight to the right screen.
- Quick Actions: + Add Talent, + Add Location, + View Applications, + Website Display.

3. Adding & Editing Talent

Agency Manager -> Talent -> Add Talent opens a tabbed editor. Nothing here is a raw WordPress field — every tab is a purpose-built section.

Tab	What it covers
General	City, Age, Availability
Profile	Languages, Skills, Experience, Video URL
Measurements	Height, Body Type, Hair Colour, Eye Colour, Measurements
Media	PDF comp card/CV. The main profile photo is set via WordPress's own Profile Photo panel in the sidebar.
Gallery	Photo gallery
Social Links	Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, Website/Portfolio
Visibility	Featured, Show on Homepage, Active
Preview	A live-rendered card using the real frontend template — see section 5

4. Adding & Editing Locations

Agency Manager -> Locations -> Add Location mirrors the Talent editor:

Tab	What it covers
General	City
Property Details	Parking, Power
Gallery	Photo gallery
Facilities	Amenities
Availability	Availability status
Map	Google Maps embed URL
Visibility	Featured, Show on Homepage, Active
Preview	A live-rendered card using the real frontend template

Visibility flags explained

- Featured — included wherever a *_featured shortcode or widget is used.
- Show on Homepage — a separate flag from Featured, so an entry can appear in a featured listing without being pinned to the homepage.
- Active — unchecking hides the entry from every public listing without deleting it. New entries default to Active.

Groups & Categories

Talent Groups and Location Categories (under Agency Manager -> Talent/Locations) each support an optional Card Image, Button Text, and Button URL, for building custom category-card layouts on any page.

5. The Preview Tab

The Preview tab on every Talent/Location editor shows exactly how that entry will appear on the live site — it reuses the same rendering code the frontend uses, so what you see is what visitors see.

It only reflects the last saved state. After making changes, click Save Draft or Update, then reopen the Preview tab (or scroll back to it) to see the refreshed card. There is no live/AJAX preview by design — this keeps the feature simple, fast, and maintainable.

6. Display Modes & the Placeholder Manager

Agency Manager -> Website Display controls how Talent and Locations appear on the site, independently per type.

Mode	Behaviour
Hidden	The relevant shortcode/widget renders nothing, and the homepage section for that type is skipped entirely.
Now Scouting	Renders placeholder cards instead of real entries — for launching a site before your roster is ready.
Live	Renders your real, Active entries.

The Placeholder Manager, on the same screen, is fully editable: Badge, Title, Description, Button Text, Button Link, one or more Scouting Images, and how many placeholder cards to show. Switching to Now Scouting immediately swaps every grid/widget/shortcode of that type over to these placeholders; switching back to Live restores real content — no code changes, no rebuilding pages.

Scouting Images: select one or more images via the same media-library button used elsewhere. Each placeholder card uses the next image in order (card 1 -> image 1, card 2 -> image 2, ...), cycling back to the first once every image has been used (3 images across 5 cards -> 1, 2, 3, 1, 2). One image is used on every card. Leaving this empty shows the original plain placeholder block.

The same screen's Homepage Section panel (heading, subheading, button, count, mode, card style, animation, per type) is what drives the homepage — see the README's Homepage section for how it connects to the *_featured shortcodes/widgets.

7. Applications

Agency Manager -> Applications reviews public form submissions, with a Talent/Location tab switch, across every form of that type.

Workflow: Submitted -> Review -> Approved -> Published, or Rejected/Archived at any point before Published.

- Approve is purely a status change — a human checkpoint. Nothing goes public automatically.
- Publish (only available once Approved) creates the real Talent/Location post from the submitted answers, starting as a draft so you can finish the profile (more photos, bio copy) before it goes live.
- Export CSV downloads a form's submissions.

Agency Manager -> Forms manages the field definitions used by the public forms (Enabled, Label, Type, Required, Order) — separate from reviewing submissions, which lives on the Applications screen.

8. Publishing Content: Shortcodes & Elementor

Every listing type is available two ways — as a shortcode, or as an Elementor widget (if Elementor is active) — both driven by the same underlying rendering code, so they always look identical.

Common shortcodes: [talent_grid], [talent_featured], [talent_carousel], [talent_slider], and the equivalent [location_...] versions, plus [talent_application_form] and [location_submission_form].

Useful attributes: limit (number of cards — e.g. limit="5" for a homepage section; count still works as an alias), columns (1-6), category / group (Talent) or type (Location), only_featured, only_active, order (newest/oldest/random), and mode (to override Website Display's mode for just one instance).

Example: [talent_featured limit="5"] shows exactly 5 Talent cards using the Homepage Section's other settings. [talent_grid columns="4" category="models" order="random"] shows a 4-column grid of just the 'models' category, shuffled.

Scouting shortcodes

[talent_scouting] and [location_scouting] always render the 'Now Scouting' placeholder cards, regardless of what the global Display Mode is currently set to — useful for placing a scouting/teaser section anywhere on the site on demand, independent of whether the rest of the site is Live. They accept limit and columns only.

Example: [talent_scouting limit="5"] always shows 5 Talent placeholder cards, even if the global Talent Display Mode is Live.

Elementor widgets

Elementor widgets offer the same filtering as dropdowns and switches in the widget panel (Number of Cards, Category/Group or Type, Only Featured, Sort Order, Only Active). The Display Mode control offers Auto (follows the global setting), Hidden, Force Now Scouting (the widget equivalent of the scouting shortcodes), and Live. Featured widgets default to 'Use Homepage Settings' but switching that off exposes the exact same filtering controls as any other widget.

Elementor Style tab -- visual controls, no code required

Every Grid/Carousel/Slider/Featured widget's Style tab has six groups of controls, so common appearance changes never require CSS or PHP:

Group	Controls
Image	Aspect Ratio (Portrait/Square/Landscape), optional custom pixel Height, Border Radius, Object Fit (Cover/Contain)
Card	Background Colour, Border Colour/Width/Radius, Padding, Shadow (None/Small/Medium/Large)
Button	Width (Auto/Full Width), Height, Border Radius, Text Size, Background/Text/Border Colour, Hover Background/Text Colour
Badge	Background, Text Colour, Border Colour -- the 'Now Scouting' badge on placeholder cards
Typography	Title, Subtitle, and Description (placeholder-card status text) typography and colour
Spacing	Card Gap, Internal Padding, Button Margin

Every one of these is a native Elementor control -- Elementor itself generates the CSS, scoped to that exact widget instance, so changes never leak to other widgets, pages, or the plugin's shortcodes.

Reset to Theme Defaults

A Reset to Theme Defaults button sits below Widget Style. Click it to restore every Style control above back to its original value -- only on the widget you are currently editing. No other widget, page, or the theme's own CSS is ever touched.

Widget Style Presets

A Widget Style section sits at the very top of the Style tab, above Reset, so a widget only ever has to be styled once:

Control	What it does
Preset	Every saved preset, by name.
Preset Name	Used by Save and Rename, below.
Load	Applies the selected preset's full Style-tab values (Image/Card/Button/Badge/Typography/Spacing) to this widget instance only. Instant -- no page reload.
Save Current Widget Style	Snapshots every current Style-tab value on this widget and saves it under the typed name -- creating a new preset, or overwriting an existing one with that exact name.
Rename Selected Preset	Renames the preset selected in the dropdown to the typed name, keeping its saved values.
Delete Selected Preset	Removes the selected preset everywhere it's stored, after a confirmation prompt.

Presets are stored once, site-wide -- not per page or per widget type -- so a preset built on a Talent Grid widget can be loaded onto a Location Slider widget just as easily. Save/Rename/Delete affect that named preset everywhere; Load only ever changes the one widget you are currently editing.

9. Theming: Theme Style

Agency Manager separates data (Talent/Location records), rendering (the templates and widgets/shortcodes that turn that data into markup), and styling -- which belongs entirely to the active theme. There is nothing to configure in wp-admin: no style dropdown, no shortcode attribute, no preset to pick.

Every card reads a small set of CSS custom properties, each with a neutral fallback built into the plugin: --am-primary, --am-secondary, --am-accent, --am-text, --am-heading, --am-button, --am-border, --am-radius. A theme defines its own look by declaring these in its own stylesheet (a plain :root{--am-primary:#...;} block); a theme that defines nothing gets the plugin's neutral default appearance.

For typography, spacing, and hover motion -- which aren't colour variables -- a theme simply targets Agency Manager's plain, stable class names directly (.am-talent-card, .am-talent-card__meta, .am-scouting-card__badge, etc.) in its own CSS, the same way it would style any other plugin's output.

Eden Cast's own maroon/gold/serif branding is implemented exactly this way, entirely inside wp-content/themes/eden-cast/assets/css/talent-locations.css -- colours, the gradient-reveal hover caption, serif headings, uppercase gold subtitles, and thin gold outlined buttons. Zero Eden Cast branding exists inside the Agency Manager plugin itself, so any other theme styles the same plugin output completely

independently.

10. Shortcode Reference Panel

Agency Manager -> Dashboard, under 'Shortcodes', lists every available shortcode grouped as Talent, Locations, and Forms. The same panel, scoped to just the relevant group, also appears on the native Talent and Locations list screens and on the Forms and Applications admin pages (since applications are created by submitting a form shortcode).

Each entry expands to show three things: What it does, When to use it, and its Available parameters -- plus a Copy button. Click Copy, then paste into an Elementor Text/Shortcode widget, a block-editor Shortcode block, or the classic editor. A small 'Shortcode copied.' message confirms it.

Interactive Shortcode Builder

Every shortcode that takes parameters also has a 'Build it' form right below its description, with a field for each real parameter matched to the right input type (a number box for Limit, a dropdown for Columns/Order By/Display Mode, a checkbox for Featured Only/Active Only, a text box for Category/Group). As you change any field, the exact shortcode text updates live in a code box, ready to copy -- no need to remember attribute names or quoting.

Search

A search box at the top of the panel filters the list as you type, matching the shortcode tag and its description -- typing 'featured' shows only talent_featured/location_featured; typing 'carousel' shows only the carousel shortcodes. A group heading (Talent/Locations/Forms) hides itself automatically if none of its shortcodes match.

Common Examples

A ready-made table at the bottom of the Dashboard panel: Homepage Featured Talent ([talent_featured limit="4"]), Homepage Featured Locations, Full Talent Page ([talent_grid]), Full Location Page, Now Scouting Talent ([talent_scouting limit="4"]), and Now Scouting Locations -- each with its own Copy button.

11. Import / Export

Agency Manager -> Import / Export moves the reusable parts of an agency between WordPress installations, as one JSON file. Sections are grouped as Content (Talent, Locations, Talent Categories, Talent Groups, Location Categories), Settings (Website Display Settings, Homepage Featured Settings, Widget Style Presets, Plugin Settings), and Optional (Forms).

Quick Actions

Button	Selects
Export Talent	Talent only
Export Locations	Locations only

Button	Selects
Export Content	Talent, Locations, Talent Categories, Talent Groups, Location Categories, Website Display Settings, Homepage Featured Settings, Widget Style Presets
Export Everything	Everything in Export Content, plus Forms and Plugin Settings

Forms is never included by Export Content — form wording, branding, and workflow are usually customised per agency rather than reused across sites, so migrating Forms is always an explicit choice (tick it manually, or use Export Everything). Individual checkboxes remain available if you want a different combination than the four Quick Actions.

- Matching is always by slug — re-importing the same file updates existing content in place rather than duplicating it. Safe to run repeatedly.
- Images are referenced by URL and downloaded into the media library on import — the source site must be reachable over the internet at import time.
- Settings sections are merged, not overwritten — importing Display Settings only changes the keys present in the file.
- You get a report after every import: created / updated / error counts per section.
- No Elementor content is ever exported or imported. The destination site's Talent/Location pages are expected to already use the plugin's widgets or shortcodes; imported content simply appears there.

Agency Manager -> Settings -> Backup & Restore is a one-click shortcut scoped to just Plugin Settings, Display Settings, Homepage Settings, and Forms — useful before a big configuration change.

12. Settings

Agency Manager -> Settings holds Agency Type (used only to set sensible Display Mode defaults during the Setup Wizard), Notification Email (who receives new-submission emails), and Backup & Restore.

13. Troubleshooting

Symptom	What it means
No Talent/Locations menu item	Something else on the site (usually the active theme) already provides those post types; Agency Manager correctly deferred to it. Every other Agency Manager screen still works normally.
Elementor widgets missing	Elementor isn't active. The widgets only register when Elementor itself is present.
Import shows 0 created	Every item matched an existing slug and was updated in place, not duplicated — check the slugs in your file if you expected new content.
New submissions aren't emailing	Check Settings -> Notification Email, and confirm outbound mail works on your host (an SMTP plugin is usually the fix).
Preview tab looks stale	It only reflects the last saved state — Save/Update the entry to refresh it.

Symptom	What it means
Cards look plain/unbranded	This is expected on a theme that defines no <code>--am-*</code> CSS variables -- the plugin ships a neutral default look on purpose. Add a <code>:root{--am-primary:....;}</code> block (and any class-targeted CSS) to the active theme's own stylesheet; see Theming: Theme Style.